All Aboard the Golden Mast

A Swashbuckling Adventure Beginning in Vilhon Reach of the Forgotten Realms

Introduction: A group of adventurers have all chanced upon tiny bottles with lengths of cloth stuffed into them. They appear to be strips torn from a larger tapestry, or perhaps fancy bed clothes. There's an identical, handwritten message on each that reads as follows: "Fortune & fame await! Meet me by the southern dock of Shulth before first light on the third day past fullest moon, and be ready to set sail! You'll know me by my fine scarlet coat. - Lord Dunstuhl."

a 4(ish)-hour adventure for 1st-3rd level characters

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All Aboard the Golden Mast

Never will ye find a less hospitable place, but never will ye have more fun.

—Proverb of the Pirate Isles

Area Information

This adventure begins in the nondescript port town of **Shulth,** not far off the **Emerald Way** along the south-eastern waters of **The Vilhon Reach**, near where it meets the **Sea of Fallen Stars**. It's mostly a pitstop for small to medium vessels on their way in and out of the larger sea toward The Vilhon Reach's many other ports. The entire town resides along the water and includes a small general store, a few knickknack vendors, a thriving fishery, sporadic residential dwellings, and a large wharf area with a combination inn, tavern, and restaurant called **The Shattered Oar**. There's also a long dock that can accommodate 8-10 ships, depending on size – there are currently four small ships, plus one medium-sized ship that just happens to be docked in the southern-most position.

Party Arrival

The adventurers could find themselves in **Shulth** for a myriad of reasons: they're from nearby and looking for an escape at sea; they wandered there from **The Emerald Road**; they came by boat, but couldn't afford further passage; they have a **Stowaway** background (*see below*); etc.

Whatever their reason for being there, they've all happened upon the same message in a bottle, and have decided to heed the call for "fortune and fame." [DM Note: Allow your players the opportunity to purchase any extra generic supplies they may want/need before the adventure begins because once they meet Lord Dunstuhl there's no turning back (unless, of course, they decide to turn back, but I don't expect them to).]

Lord Dunstuhl

Lord Octavius Overdale Merriweather Dunstuhl is a slight, garish human that swears he has ancient high elf in his "Overdale bloodline." He wears black pants – stuffed into shiny, brass-buckled, mid-calf black boots – that are cinched at the waist with a delicate, yellow rope that he claims was once the curtain pull in an elven castle. To this, he adds a ruffled, open-chested (to show off his many bejeweled necklaces) white shirt that he tucks into his pants. Topping it all off, he sports a double-breasted, brilliantly scarlet coat with many yellow accents that *almost* match his rope belt. The coat is obviously too big for him; his hands often disappear into its sleeves, and it nearly drags the ground as he walks.

Very little is known about Lord Dunstuhl around **Shulth** except for what he's told people (probably several times over). Aside from his tales of elvish heritage, the main tales one is likely to hear pertain to his previous career as a dread pirate on the **Sea of Fallen Stars**. According to the legend from his own mouth, any ship that merely thought they glimpsed the scarlet banners on his fabled Golden Mast would take to oar and navigate away from him with speed. The story of how he ended up adrift on land with no treasure, crew, or ship, however, varies:

Roll 1d6 to Determine Dunstuhl's Story

1 – He was made to walk the plank in a mutiny, but survived due to his tremendous skill and moxie.
2 – He gave up the pirate's life for a woman who eventually scorned him and took everything.
3 – Several pirate crews ganged up and attacked his ship while they slept – he was the sole survivor.
4 – He surrendered his ship and all he had to one of the Overdale high elves.
5 – Dragons!
6 – Everything still exists, hidden away, waiting for him to come get it.

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The Adventure Begins

The adventurers arrive at the southern dock of **Shulth** just as the mysterious message stated. There they see **Lord Dunstuhl**, alone, standing nervously next to a modest-sized ship moored to the last berth. Lord Dunstuhl stops wringing his hands and beams as he notices the party.

> "Greetings, travelers, and, well, my faithful new crew! I am **Lord Octavius Overdale Merriweather Dunstuhl**. I take it you've noticed my fine scarlet coat?" He pulls at the breasts of his coat in a showy gesture. "Quick introductions are in order, but then we must make haste to this terrific vessel, **The Haberdasher**, if we're to be full sail by sunrise! So, who wants to go first?"

Here the party will make quick introductions and Lord Dunstuhl will interact with them joyfully. Once this is complete, he'll usher everyone quickly onto the Haberdasher ahead of him while he unmoors the ship, and the players will instantly roll for initiative.

The Haberdasher

As the heroes step aboard **The Haberdasher** ahead of **Lord Dunstuhl**, two **lizardfolk** emerge from below decks. Lord Dunstuhl yells something about heathen bandits, drawing their ire, and they attack. The ship is fairly small, so the combat will be tight. Lord Dunstuhl will remain on the dock throughout all combat rounds. [DM Note: If a player attempts to toss someone overboard, have the victim roll a *STR* save to see if the player is successful. If someone is knocked off, assume they will re-board the ship and re-enter combat after 3 rounds (unless a player rolls a natural 20 and you decide whoever gets knocked overboard is eaten by sharks, decides to bail, or something else).]

There are two more standard lizardfolk left below decks, as well as their leader, **Straaz**. If combat is going too well, or the adventurers do something that would alert them aside from standard combat actions and spells, have one or both of those standard lizardfolk go topside; otherwise, leave them below with their leader for a future encounter. Once the combat above decks is finished, Lord Dunstuhl will come aboard and say he'll go about readying the ship to leave port while the adventurers check the rest of the ship. In theory, they'll then encounter Straaz and whatever guard he has left; however, they may choose to stay up top and help Lord Dunstuhl. If so, don't forget that Straaz & Co. are below and will likely come see what's going on when they notice they're moving. [DM Note: If you are running this module with lower-level characters, use your discretion as to whether or not to omit the two lizardfolk crew below decks with Straaz as such an encounter may be too difficult for adventurers below level three.]

After all the lizardfolk and their leader are defeated, the adventurers may choose to investigate the ship. If they do this before Lord Dunstuhl has a chance to go below decks, and succeed on a *DC 8 Perception* check when searching, they'll find paperwork stating that The Haberdasher was, in fact, Straaz's ship. Lord Dunstuhl has used the party of adventurers to steal it for him. Without this information, the party will believe Lord Dunstuhl's lie that it's his ship and the lizardfolk were merely bandits attempting to steal it from him since they likely knew he previously had no crew to protect it. [DM Note: There's also a possibility that the encounter with Straaz will come to a non-violent conclusion. If that's the case, he becomes an NPC that's willing to help the party find the treasure in question, but he will absolutely, under no circumstances whatsoever, even with a natural 20, work with Dunstuhl. This situation becomes mostly up to you to riff and see how the story moves forward.]

The Vilhon Reach

At this point, regardless of the outcome and what the adventurers know, the ship should be well into **The Vilhon Reach** as **Lord Dunstuhl**'s top priority would have been to get the ship free and away from **Shulth** as soon as possible.

If the party knows of Lord Dunstuhl's treachery, they may decide to kill him. Lord Dunstuhl will protest greatly, saying this was all for the sake of treasure. He'll say he needed to deceive the party because otherwise no one would believe him, or they would just try to steal his map and find the treasure themselves (FYI: the messages in the bottles were written on strips torn from the edges of the treasure map). If the party decides to kill him anyway, it wouldn't involve combat as Lord Dunstuhl is weak and unarmed. When looted, Lord Dunstuhl will yield 12 gp, jewelry worth roughly 10 gp, the treasure map, a small vial of red liquid, and a conch shell. Without Lord Dunstuhl, the party will have to make checks to both sail (*DC 11 DEX without an applicable skill*) and navigate (*DC 11 INT without an*

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applicable skill) the ship, and may likely get off course, taking extra time and eating into their rations (unless Straaz is with them, then his sailing expertise can get them where they're going posthaste). [DM Note: If they happen to toss Lord Dunstuhl overboard before they get the map, have it come floating to the surface and have them come up with some way to get it, using applicable checks for things like swimming, throwing nets, etc. They would not be able to loot the other items, however.]

If the confrontation with Lord Dunstuhl is non-lethal, or the party doesn't know they were duped, Lord Dunstuhl will divulge his plan:

> "**The Pirate Isles** are a treasure trove, but also a terribly dangerous, unsavory place to find oneself. Luckily, I now have you fearsome adventurers at my side – the fortunes we will collect from this will be immeasurable!" He holds up the map triumphantly. "Only one thing stands in our way: **Grandeur Kaine**. He and his men block the path to our fortune as it lies beyond their waters in the **Sea of Fallen Stars**. My plan is to catch a great creature from the deeps and then unleash it upon Kaine, securing our passage through his domain while he's busy with the beast!"

Lord Dunstuhl goes on to explain how he has acquired a magical conch from a group of **Kraken Priests** that, when played, can subdue even the most savage beast of the sea. Lord Dunstuhl knows where to find such a creature, but it will be up to the party to figure out how to lure it out of the depths so the conch can be used. [DM Note: If Lord Dunstuhl is gone, and the conch went with him, the party will (most likely) make their way directly to the treasure location on the map, thus having to fight off Grandeur Kaine directly. If this is the case, you can skip over the **Sea of Fallen Stars** section and go directly to **The Pirate Isles** section. If Lord Dunstuhl is gone, but the conch remains, a party member may discover its magical function by succeeding on a *DC 15 Insight* or *DC 12 Arcana* check (the DCs drop by five if a party member decides to cast *Detect Magic* on the conch first). Even with this information, however, the party will have to determine what, if anything, they can do with the conch without Dunstuhl to guide them. This scenario can play out to your discretion, though the conch will only work at the red star as detailed in the following section.]

Sea of Fallen Stars

Once the ship spills out of the **Vilhon Reach**, the adventurers will find themselves in the **Sea of Fallen Stars**. At this point, **Lord Dunstuhl** will show them the treasure map, and indicate that they are headed for the red star that originally marked a spot to avoid because it's known to be the lair of a vicious sea creature that sometimes torments sailors. With the conch, though, Dunstuhl is sure the party will not only be safe, but they'll be able to charm the beast, or whatever comes to the surface, into doing their bidding; however, Dunstuhl says he isn't confident enough in himself to use the conch, and one of his new crew will have to do it. Have the party assign someone this task.

Before that comes into play, though, the party will have to do something to ensure the creature comes up from the depths. This will be completely up to the creativity of the party. If they don't come up with something themselves, have Dunstuhl suggest tying a rope around one of them and tossing them overboard as bait as if they're fishing for the creature. [DM Note: This is a fairly predictable idea, so feel free to suggest whatever else comes to mind. That said, though, if the party requires Dunstuhl's assistance rather than coming up with their own idea, give them a -4 when they roll on the Sea Encounter Table. When the party has decided on their tactic, you can have them roll whatever checks might be applicable for what they're attempting to do: *Strength* for holding the rope for Dunstuhl's idea, *Nature* for the person in the water to see if they're convincing bait, *Animal Handling* if they decide to try to catch their own bait, and so on, deciding how to handle poor or exceptional roll outcomes as they happen; conversely, you can let the party roleplay this without rolling any dice and just allow their idea (or Dunstuhl's) to work as intended.]

When the party's plan, whatever it may be, is put into action, have everyone roll a d20, add the values together, then divide the total by the number of party members to find the average. Use that average to determine exactly what will rise to engage your adventurers:

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Sea Encounter Table	
1-2	1 Crawling Crab Claw
3-4	1 Giant Frog
5-6	1d6 Reef Sharks
7-8	2d4 Sea Spawn
9-10	1d4 Sea Hags
11-12	1d6 Deep Scions
13-14	1d4 Plesiosauruses
15-16	1 Cursed Pirate Ship
17-18	1 Dragon Turtle
19-20	1 Kraken

Now that the sea encounter is prepared, have the assigned conch blower roll a *Performance* check with a DC of the average the party rolled on the Sea Encounter Table minus four. [DM Note: For example, if they rolled an average of 14, they would have to succeed on a DC 10 *Performance* check to pacify those 1d4 Plesiosauruses.] Give the party two chances to successfully complete the check, allowing them to roll with advantage if another party member offers to help. [DM Note: You may have Lord Dunstuhl suggest that someone do something to calm or inspire the adventurer blowing the conch if you so choose.] If they fail both checks, whatever they summoned will retreat, realizing something is wrong and these sailors aren't safe to torment. If they succeed, Lord Dunstuhl will give their subdued minion(s) the following command:

> "Vicious <insert sea encounter here>, you now bend to the will of the great **Kraken Priests**! You will seek out the dread pirate **Grandeur Kaine**, and you will not be released until you taste his blood!"

At this, Dunstuhl will empty a small vial into the water, causing whatever's been charmed to go into a kind of frenzy and take off toward their prey, and the party sets sail after them.

The Pirate Isles

Regardless of how they get there, the party will eventually arrive near the marked location on the map. If they've successfully charmed a sea creature, they'll find it wreaking havoc on **Grandeur Kaine's** forces. If **Lord Dunstuhl** is still with the party, he will insist that they use the distraction to get to the treasure location; however, in spite of Dunstuhl's insistence, or if he's no longer present, the party may decide to join the fray and fight off the remaining pirates on Kaine's ship, **The Opulence**. If this is the case, use the following table to determine how many pirates the adventurers will encounter (use the same number from the Sea Encounter Table):

Remaining Pirates Table	
1-2	4 Cannons, 6 Pirates + Grandeur Kaine
3-4	2 Cannons, 6 Pirates + Grandeur Kaine
5-6	6 Pirates + Grandeur Kaine
7-8	5 Pirates + Grandeur Kaine
9-10	4 Pirates + Grandeur Kaine
11-12	3 Pirates + Grandeur Kaine
13-14	2 Pirates + Grandeur Kaine
15-16	1 Pirate + Grandeur Kaine
17-18	Grandeur Kaine
19-20	None!

[DM Note: For this encounter, if the party faces canons (which isn't likely, but possible) each member will suffer 1 damage per cannon every round that there's a pirate not engaged and therefore free to fire the cannons.] Those that survive this fight will move on to the treasure location on the map to collect their riches.

If the adventurers heed Dunstuhl's advice and sail past their diversion, heading to the treasure location immediately, they will be able to sort through their loot unimpaired; however, as a crafty, dangerous pirate, **Grandeur Kaine** will ambush the party on the treasure island and try to take back what he believes to be rightfully his.

Grandeur Kaine

Grandeur Kaine is a stout, flamboyant halfling whose looks seem completely contrary to his reputation. He wears an oversized, wide-brimmed bush hat with feathers from some unknown exotic species of bird strapped to each side by a polished brass band. His ears are pierced several times, and his long, black hair is often overlooked for the extremely well-manicured, enormous handlebar mustache that extends past the edges of his face. His blue overcoat with brass adornments is dyed leather and covers a white shirt not unlike **Lord Dunstuhl's** save it's cinched at the top with a white handkerchief of the same delicate fabric. His pants and boots, while clearly high quality, are only a backdrop for the vibrant green dragon skin loin cloth he wears under his brass-buckled leather belt. Completing his look is the huge (for a halfling) rapier with intricately crafted basket guard that always seems to shimmer unnaturally.

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If Dunstuhl is still with the party whenever they encounter Kaine, upon seeing each other Kaine will immediately say:

> "You…I should have known. This nonsense has your messy fingerprints all over it. I gave you a chance to start over! I gave you a chance to be free! You won't get another…"

Clearly these two have some history. [DM Note: If the party encounters Kaine on his ship, he gets a +2 to all non-damage rolls.]

Once the encounter with Kaine comes to its conclusion, if either Dunstuhl or Kaine are still standing, the adventures may pry as to the details of their previous relationship. Both will divulge that they were once partners, but Dunstuhl's version of the story is that he was constantly disrespected and treated more like a pet than a companion so he escaped to plot his revenge; Kaine's version (the truth) is that Dunstuhl's mouth landed the crew in one too many unnecessary brawls and they were conspiring to take matters into their own hands. Essentially to save Dunstuhl's life, Kaine fed his partner a strong sleeping potion so he appeared dead and tossed him overboard in a barrel with only his aforementioned items. [DM Note: It is *very* unlikely that Kaine will be left standing as pirates do not commonly become amicable with those that attempt to steal their treasure, but in D&D anything is possible!]

When looted, **Grandeur Kaine** will yield 40 gp, his hat, his green dragonhide loin cloth, and his magical rapier, **The Rapier of Grandeur** (see stats below).

The Treasure

No matter how the adventure plays out, (hopefully?) the party should arrive at the **X** on the map. With Dunstuhl still along for the ride, the party won't need to worry about the directions on the map; however, if he's not around, the party will have to determine where exactly their treasure is hidden. As the directions vaguely state, the party is looking for an island with a single tree that also has a rock that molten copper has been poured over to make it appear like a wax seal. [DM Note: If you have a group that likes to roll, you can have them roll for Perception or Investigation to find the island, and then they can roll for Strength, etc. to move the rock, dig up the treasure, unlock the chest, and so on; otherwise, just allow them to recognize the island once they're in the right location on the map and simply talk them through unearthing and opening the treasure chest.]

Treasure Contents

The wooden chest opens with a cloud of dust and an acrid smell the assaults the nostrils. Upon looking inside, the adventurers find the following items:

- Several bottles of vintage wine, one of which appears to have been broken when the chest was first buried.
- Three wine-stained outfits in a similar style to what Grandeur Kaine was wearing.
- A velvet pouch containing the bones of a large bird.
- What appears to be a hand-sized cannon with a flint mechanism for igniting the flammable powder.
- An incomplete spell scroll.
- A note with a broken elven seal that simply reads, "IOU."
- 500 gold dragons.

The End

Now that the treasure has been dispersed, this adventure has come to an end. If your party wants to move forward, you can pull on the string of the mysterious "IOU" to setup the next hook or follow the gold dragons back to Waterdeep where adventures are always waiting. Hopefully you've enjoyed running this adventure, and hopefully your players had a blast! Oh yeah, before I forget, if you're asking yourself, "what about the Golden Mast?" well…it never existed, Dunstuhl made it up. *The end.*

Final Notes

The real beauty of playing Dungeons & Dragons lies in the simple truth that nearly anything can happen at any time. With that in mind, I tried not to go too overboard with options and explanations for what could happen as I want the game and story to feel as much yours as mine. I also didn't include any specific game maps because I wanted to leave it up to the DM's preference. Basically, though, all you'll need is a medium/small ship for **The Haberdasher**, maybe a medium/large ship for **The Opulence**, and an island (preferably with one tree and a copper rock); however, depending on what the party does, other maps may become necessary. Luckily, the internet is an absolute treasure trove for all of these, and you're likely to find something much better than I'd make myself anyway.

If you have any questions, concerns, comments or curse words for me, send them to futhatswho@gmail.com.

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Appendix A: Creature & NPC Statistics

The information concerning the creatures and NPCs your players will encounter can be found below.

Lizardfolk Crew

Medium humanoid (lizardfolk), neutral

Armor Class 13
Hit Points 22 (4d8+ 4)
Speed 30 ft., swim 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
15 (+2)	10 (0)	13 (+1)	7 (-2)	12 (+1)	7 (-2)

Proficiency Bonus +2
Skills Perception +3, Survival +5, Stealth +4
Senses passive Perception 13
Languages Draconic
Challenge 1/2 (100 XP)

Hold Breath. The lizardfolk can hold its breath for 15 minutes.

Description

Unlike most lizardfolk, the crew of **The Haberdasher** are ex-pirates that "went straight" and have spent most of their lives among the more common races of **Faerûn**. They react to situations more like those warm-blooded races than their cold-blooded brethren.

Actions

Multiattack. The lizardfolk makes two melee attacks, each one with a different weapon.
Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing damage.
Heavy Club. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6 + 2) bludgeoning damage.
Javelin. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +2 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 30/120 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing damage.

Straaz

Medium humanoid (lizardfolk), neutral

Armor Class 15 (+2)
Hit Points 44 (8d8 + 12)
Speed 30 ft., swim 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
18 (+4)	15 (+2)	13 (+1)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	15 (+2)

Proficiency Bonus +2
Skills Acrobatics +6, Athletics +8, Persuasion +6
Senses passive Perception 13
Languages Draconic
Challenge 2 (450 XP)

Hold Breath. As a lizardfolk, Straaz can hold his breath for 15 minutes.
Lightfooted. Straaz can take the Dash or Disengage action as a bonus action on each of his turns.
Suave Defense. While Straaz is wearing light or no armor and wielding no shield, his AC includes his Charisma modifier.

Description

Straaz is a strong Swashbuckler who's spent his entire life on the open water. He will fight tooth and nail to protect the small life he's carved out for himself.

Actions

Multiattack. Straaz makes two attacks: one with a dagger and one with his rapier.
Bite. Melee Weapon Attack: +6 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6 + 2) piercing damage.
Dagger. Melee or Ranged Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft. or range 20/60 ft., one target. Hit: 4 (1d4 + 2) piercing damage.
Rapier. Melee Weapon Attack: +4 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 6 (1d8 + 2) piercing damage.

Pirate Crew

Medium humanoid (human, etc.), neutral evil

Armor Class 14 (studded leather)
Hit Points 32 (5d8 + 10)
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
12 (+1)	14 (+2)	14 (+2)	10 (+0)	10 (+0)	11 (+0)

Proficiency Bonus +2
Skills Intimidation +2
Senses passive Perception 10

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Languages Common
Challenge 1/2 (100 XP)

Description

Grandeur Kaine's crew are exceedingly loyal and will come to his aid even at the risk of their own peril, and once the fighting starts it's kill or be killed – no surrender.

Actions

Scimitar. *Melee Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 4 (1d6 + 1) slashing damage.*
Light Crossbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack: +3 to hit, range 80 ft./320 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d8 + 1) piercing damage.*

Grandeur Kaine

Small humanoid (halfling), neutral evil

Armor Class 17 (+3)
Hit Points 99 (18d8 + 18)
Speed 30 ft.

STR	DEX	CON	INT	WIS	CHA
10 (+0)	18 (+4)	13 (+1)	15 (+2)	10 (+0)	16 (+3)

Proficiency Bonus +3
Skills Acrobatics +7, Athletics +3, Persuasion +6, Vehicles (water) +10
Senses passive Perception 10
Languages Common
Challenge 7 (2,900 XP)

Flourish. *Grandeur Kaine adds his Charisma modifier to the damage roll for his rapier attacks (included in the attack).*
Sea Legs. *Grandeur Kaine has advantage on ability checks and saving throws to resist being knocked prone.*
Piercing Spark (1/3 turns). *Grandeur Kaine may blast a spark of electricity at a creature or object within 120 feet from the end of his blade. Make a ranged spell attack against the target. On a hit, the target takes 1d8 lightning damage. A flammable object hit by this spell ignites if it isn't being worn or carried.*

Description

Grandeur Kaine has spent his life making a name for himself and his crew, and he prides himself on backing it up. Few, if any, have crossed swords with this pirate and lived to tell the tale.

Actions

Multiattack. *Grandeur Kaine makes two attacks: one with his hand crossbow and one with his rapier (casting Piercing Spark counts as a rapier attack in this instance).*
Hand Crossbow. *Ranged Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, range 30/120 ft., one target. Hit: 5 (1d6 + 4) piercing damage.*
Rapier. *Melee Weapon Attack: +7 to hit, reach 5 ft., one target. Hit: 8 (1d8 + 4) piercing damage.*

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Appendix B: Booty (Items)

The information concerning the items your players may encounter can be found below.

Kraken Priest Conch

Wondrous Item, legendary

The wielder of this conch can charm an aquatic creature within 60 feet after completing a successful Performance check against said creature's Constitution. The charmed creature will take one order from its new master and will remain charmed until the given task is complete. Once the effect wears off, the wielder can either release the creature or attempt to re-charm it; however, if the Performance check fails while attempting to re-charm, the creature will immediately attack the wielder with advantage.

Rapier of Grandeur

Weapon (rapier), artifact

A long rapier with an intricately crafted basket guard that always seems to shimmer unnaturally. It was once the favored weapon of the dread pirate Grandeur Kaine, but its origins are otherwise unknown.

Piercing Spark. Once every three turns, the wielder of this weapon may blast a spark of electricity at a creature or object within 120 feet from the end of the blade. Make a ranged spell attack against the target. On a hit, the target takes 1d8 lightning damage. A flammable object hit by this spell ignites if it isn't being worn or carried.

This spell's damage increases by 1d8 when you reach 5th level (2d8), 11th level (3d8), and 17th level (4d8).

Proficiency with a rapier allows you to add your proficiency bonus to the attack roll for any attack you make with it.

Flintlock Pistol

Weapon (pistol), uncommon

Among a cache of plundered pirate loot, you find what appears to be a hand-sized cannon with a flint mechanism for igniting the flammable powder.

You have a +1 bonus to attack and damage rolls made with this unusual weapon.

[DM Note: It's up to you to decide whether a character has proficiency with a firearm. Characters in most D&D worlds wouldn't have such proficiency. During their downtime, characters can use the training rules in the Player's Handbook to acquire proficiency, assuming that they have enough ammunition to keep the weapons working while mastering their use.]

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Appendix C: Stowaway Background

Stowaway

"Every day is a chance to start over. Any day can be bad, surely, but any day can be good, can be great, and that promise, that potential, is a beautiful thing indeed."

— *The Stowaway*

You've made your way through the world by going, literally, wherever the wind takes you. You may come from a well-to-do family, an unfortunate life as an urchin, or anywhere in between, but, for whatever reason, the call of the open sea and the rush of living the secret, dangerous life of a stowaway was too loud to ignore.

You're adept at stealth and survival, able to slip unnoticed onto nearly any ship and sustain yourself by silently scavenging rations or, in a pinch, dispatching other stowaways like rats or gulls for a meal. You've also picked up on many of the ins and outs of seafaring without ever lifting a finger.

While choosing this background is beneficial because it gives you innate maritime knowledge, you must decide why you elected to become a career stowaway. Further, you must decide what made you give it up for the life of an adventurer. Did the near-constant uncertainty take its toll on you? Did the lack of purpose leave you feeling empty over time? Did the omnipresent fear of being caught finally drive you toward new pursuits?

Skill Proficiencies: Stealth, Survival
Tool Proficiencies: Navigator's tools, Thieves' tools
Equipment: A small knife, Thieves' tools, a mess kit, a book you've likely read several times (to pass the time – when you have light, that is), common clothes, and a pouch containing 2 gp.

Feature: Hidey-hole

Rather than being proficient in getting out of tight spaces, your forte is getting into them. Unless an area you hide in is specifically searched, you can disappear quickly into cramped spaces where others may easily be found, especially on ships, and can remain there for an indeterminate amount of time (at your Dungeon Master's discretion, of course).

Suggested Characteristics

Although Stowaways can come from any walk of life, there are common traits that many seem to share. Years of stealth, solitude, and barely scrapping by have shaped them into who they are today.

d8	Personality Trait
1	I sometimes feel uneasy in wide open spaces.
2	I'm more comfortable when I don't have a plan.
3	I'm not picky about food or lodgings.
4	I prefer small groups to large crowds.
5	I say and do before I bother to think.
6	I rarely pass up an opportunity to take a chance.
7	I drop in and out of peoples' lives like a shadow.
8	I was a loner, a rebel, but now I'm ready to belong.

d6	Ideal
1	**Honest.** I always leave payment for whatever I may take. (Lawful)
2	**Invisible.** I take only memories, leave only footprints. (Neutral)
3	**Helpful.** I try to fix something during the journey so I leave the ship better than I found it. (Good)
4	**Angst.** I do what I want, to hell with how it affects others. (Evil)
5	**Carefree.** I prefer to let the wind do my thinking for me. (Chaotic)
6	**Adrift.** I'm along for the ride, ready for whatever comes next. (Any)

d6	Bond
1	I take orders from one person: me.
2	I find love at every port, but never settle down.
3	The sea is my mistress, and I love her.
4	I've found a freedom I can never let go.
5	I find ships to be as good a companion as any living being.
6	I am addicted to the thrill of the unknown.

d6	Flaw
1	I feel compelled to leave, even when I want to stay.
2	Sometimes I cause rations to spoil, just to see what happens.
3	I often waste what little money I acquire on ale.
4	I find it hard to make more than acquaintances.
5	I assume everyone has something to hide.
6	I've been known to steal random items I don't even need from sailors just because I can.

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Appendix D: Treasure Map

